Similarly Hanuman, a monkey-god, was enlisted in the service of Lord Rama in the epic *Ramayana*; scholars see in his appearance the absorption of animist nature-worship into Vedic theism, and the accommodation of south Asia's indigenous peoples into the Hindu fold. Characters depicted in the epics as animals with anthropomorphic characteristics may in fact have been Adivasis: Hanuman was perhaps the leader of a monkey-totem Adivasi tribe, Jatayu that of a vulture-totem tribe and Jambuvan of a tribe using bear totems.[13]

Another interesting example is that of the god Jagannath in Odisha, famous for his *ratha* or chariot. It's a beautiful, elaborately carved wooden vehicle used for a sanctified purpose—to wheel an image of a deity worshipped by millions to a temple in full public view—but it has given its name to the English word, 'juggernaut'.

The word is a colonial mangling of Jagannath (Sanskrit for 'Lord of the World'), a manifestation of the god Krishna. Legend has it that in ancient times, King Indradyumna chanced upon the corpse of Lord Krishna, who had been slain by a hunter, and was informed by the god Vishnu that he should make a wooden statue of the Lord and inter his bones in it. The great sage Vishwakarma, the architect of the gods, undertook the task on condition that he not be disturbed while carving the statue. When, after fifteen days, the impatient king went to enquire about the progress of the sculpture, the irritated sage abandoned it unfinished, without hands or feet. King Indradyumna prayed to Brahma, the Creator, who breathed life into the statue by giving it eyes and a soul, though He could do nothing about the stumps where the deity's limbs should have been. This consecrated statue is worshipped at the Jagannath temple in Puri, in the eastern state of Odisha.

The legend almost certainly masks a different story. As I have noted, as Hinduism spread through the subcontinent, it absorbed local animist and tribal faiths it encountered, by accommodating their images of worship into the Hindu pantheon. Jagannatha was probably a Tribal god who was reimagined, through this legend, as a manifestation of Krishna (himself an incarnation of Vishnu), his somewhat rough and limbless appearance explained through an elaborate story that fits within Hindu lore. One of the ways of ensuring the new deity's acceptance by the